

These Web sites also offer classified services, so you need not scan the newspaper for a great deal on a second-hand car, or a job listing by your dream company. Ryze also has an offline meeting called the Mixer. Such meetings capitalise on online introductions and, with frequent interactions, develop the beginnings of a long business relationship.

Premium membership offers the advantage of your own network and the ability to manage your contacts.

Ecademy (www.ecademy.com) offers a whole range of services, right from managing your meetings, to overseeing your schedule. Indeed, social networking Web sites provide just the very platform to widen contacts that might be the key to your success. But, are they successful?

Professional benefits

Debjyoti Das, Founder, CEO and President of Zytes Inc, California, US, and a LinkedIn member, shares his experience, "Suppose I wish to meet Venture Capitalists (VCs) to help fund my startup—Zytes. Normally, I would start asking friends and colleagues if they would introduce me to VCs. With online social networking sites, I can simply look up VCs, research them, make my plans and then find out who in my network can help me reach them."

Business networking sites are a boon to entrepreneurs and freelancers. Samir Jhaveri—an industrialist from Mumbai—swears by Ryze. He's a member since October 2003, and is already reaping benefits. "I have generated reasonably big business, especially from offshore clients. The network has no geographical boundaries," he emphasises. Ditto for Prashant Poladia of Mumbai, who has



RAM GOPAL RAO, Managing director, Argosy, Inter Search India Ltd

“ I have access to **three** important people through just three phone calls—the **US President**, the **Russian President** and the **Pope!** ”

bagged five big projects for his software company, Blue Spot Technologies, through online networking.

Konstatin Guericke, Vice President Marketing LinkedIn, California, says, "We are business-only, and have 5,00,000 members who have uploaded a total of 20 million qualified business contacts into the network."

LinkedIn boasts of over a million users in software development, telecommunications and IT industries. Adds Mehul Patel, Director, KIPL Net, Mumbai, "Social networking makes sense for so

many small, mid-sized and SoHo companies to advertise. They can have their ads running, for one-tenth of what they would spend on a search engine, portal, contest Web site, etc." Does that mean that these Web sites are a sure-shot means to procure instant business?

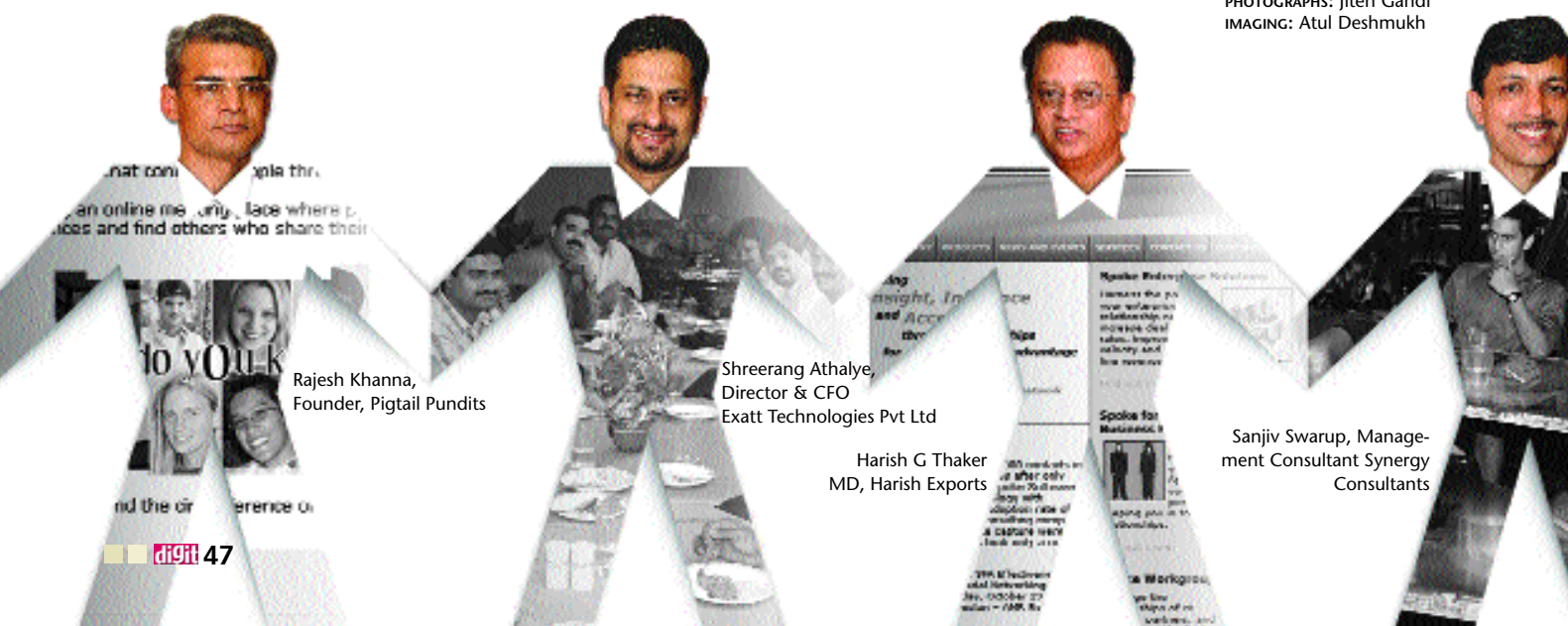
Krishna Unni, Founder of Pigtail Pundits, (www.pigtailpundits.com) a Web-based company, and head of the Mumbai Business Network Mixer, vehemently denies this. "An online introduction is just the beginning—it's not like you register today, and expect crores of business tomorrow." Even offline meetings cannot guarantee instant riches. "One has to build a relationship and only then can one expect potential business."

Sucheta Kelkar, a freelance software developer from Mumbai, agrees, "You never do business with strangers, and the online profile is just a way to reduce the strangeness." She makes it a point to be in touch with the message boards, and be present for as many gatherings as possible.

There are many who still haven't made a business deal through these Web sites, but this does not deter them. Rather, they are confident of the long term gains, and that's what keeps them inviting more friends and acquaintances to such networks.

Headhunters also frequent these Web sites. According to Patel, "Name the industry, and you have freelancers ready to work at affordable prices." Vishal Verma, CEO, Innovision, a Gurgaon based company into Web designing and multimedia services, also posts regularly on networking Web sites, when in need of skilled people. Guericke believes, "Whether you are hiring an employee, or closing a business deal, introductions are key."

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